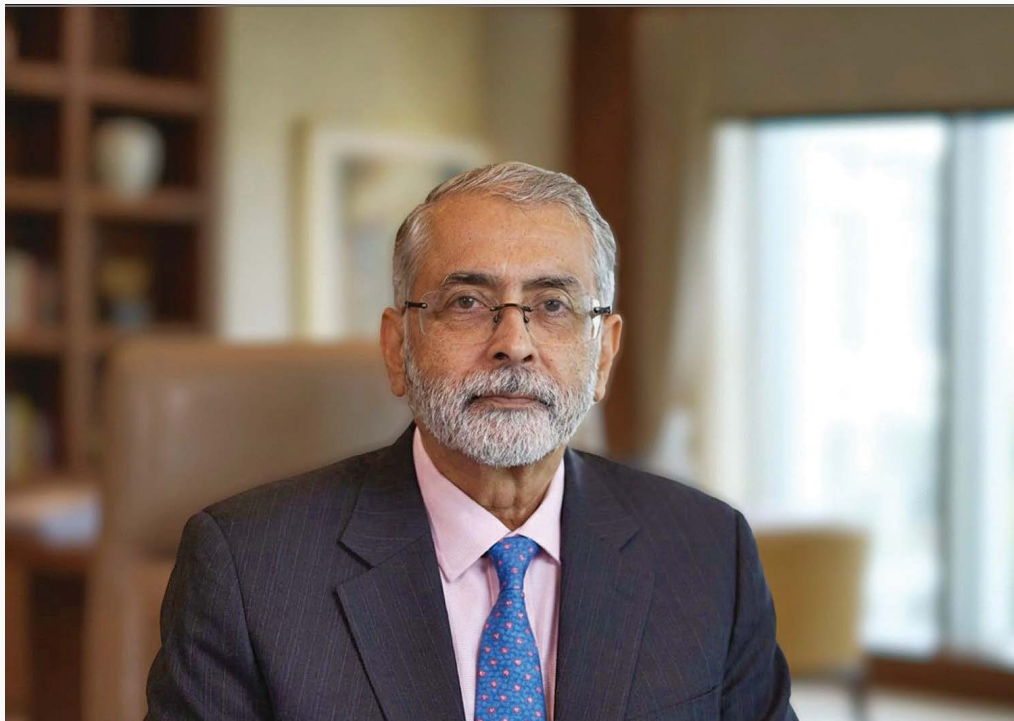




# The Lawyer Who Built One of India's Leading Law Firms



**Dr. Shardul S. Shroff**

Founder and Executive Chairman, Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co

In 2015, Dr. Shardul S. Shroff inherited a 95 year legacy and almost nothing else, no Mumbai office, three hundred people. A decade later, SAM is one of India's largest full-service law firms.

**W**hen the erstwhile Amarchand Mangaldas split in 2015, Dr. Shardul S. Shroff did not inherit a functioning institution so much as a name with history attached to it. "It was a new dawn, the firm was ours to build," he has written of that moment, describing what became Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co as effectively a startup carrying a century old legacy: roughly 300 people, four offices, and no presence at all in Mumbai, India's financial capital. A decade on, the firm employs over 1,000 lawyers including 190 partners across eight cities, and Shroff, its Founder and Executive Chairman, has spent that decade proving a specific point: that a law firm can outgrow the family name on its letterhead.

That point is not rhetorical. Of a partnership of a thousand practising lawyers, only five are family members, a ratio Shroff treats as evidence rather than coincidence. "We are one partnership, one balance sheet, and

one profit and loss account pan India," he says, describing a governance structure built around a nine member management board, a five criteria partner evaluation framework, and non-lawyer specialists running operations, technology and AI, a structure designed explicitly to survive its founders.

The expansion since has followed a disciplined rhythm rather than opportunism. Shroff has followed a personal rule of replenishing or launching two practice areas every two years, building an insolvency practice from three lawyers to more than fifty after the IBC came into force in 2016, then repeating the pattern for real estate after RERA, for data protection, and now for artificial intelligence and ESG. The firm rolled out Harvey AI across its practice during the pandemic years and, in February 2026, published Bharat for AI: Enabling Frameworks for Trust, a collection of essays arguing for India specific AI

governance frameworks, a natural extension of Shroff's own seat on the Government of India's Insolvency Law Committee, Company Law Committee, and, most recently, the IBBI Expert Committee on mediation under the IBC.

The recognition has compounded alongside the rebuild. Shroff holds the National Law Day Award from the President of India, features on The Economic Times' Gamechangers of India list, and has been named to Legal 500's Hall of Fame for Banking and Finance, while the firm itself was ranked Band 1 across a dozen practice areas by Chambers and Partners Asia Pacific in 2026 and named India National Law Firm of the Year in 2025. Shroff has also waived his own salary as Executive Chairman, a gesture that reads less as sacrifice than as consistent with his central argument, that an institution matters more than any individual inside it, including the one who built it.